

LIVE

Learning Space

NEWSPAPER

8th March, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

10th WEEK



REINVIGORATE NEIGHBOURHOOD FIRST

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... India and its Neighborhood- Relations.

4

Make the neighbourhood first again

India is sliding towards a situation where it is neither feared nor loved by other South Asian countries



SUHASINI HAIDAR

Almost four years after Prime Minister Narendra Modi began his term with a "Neighbourhood First" moment, by inviting leaders of all South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) countries to his swearing-in ceremony, India's neighbourhood policy is clearly adrift. New Delhi's connect with its South Asian neighbours is weaker than it has been for a very long time.

A perfect storm?

The first problem is that for various reasons other governments in the SAARC region are either not on ideal terms with New Delhi, or facing political headwinds. In the Maldives, President Yameen Abdul Gayoom has gone out of his way to challenge the Modi government, whether it is on his crack-down on the opposition, invitations to China, or even breaking with New Delhi's effort to isolate Pakistan at SAARC. In Nepal, the K.P. Sharma Oli government is certainly not India's first choice, and Kathmandu's invitation to the Pakistani Prime Minister this week confirms the chill. And no matter which party is in power in Pakistan, it is difficult to see Delhi pushing for official dialogue, especially with the military on the ascendant once again. In other parts of the neighbourhood, where relations have been comparatively better for the past few years, upcoming elections could turn the tables on India. In Sri Lanka, the recent lo-

cal election results that have gone the way of the Mahinda Rajapaksa-backed party could be a portent of his future re-election. In Afghanistan, Bhutan and Bangladesh, elections this year and the next could pose challenges for India.

The next problem is the impact of China's unprecedented forays into each of these countries. Instead of telling the Nepal government to sort out issues with India, for example, as it had in the past, China opened up an array of alternative trade and connectivity options after the 2015 India-Nepal border blockade: from the high-way to Lhasa, cross-border railway lines to the development of dry ports. In Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, the Maldives and Pakistan, China holds strategic real estate, which could also be fortified militarily in the future. At present, it means China has a stake in the internal politics of those countries. While China's growing presence in infrastructure and connectivity projects has been well-documented, its new interest in political mediation must be watched more carefully as a result. When China stepped in to negotiate a Rohingya refugee return agreement between Myanmar and Bangladesh, or host a meeting of Afghanistan and Pakistan's foreign ministers to help calm tensions and bring both on board with the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) connection between them, or offer to mediate between the Maldivian government and the opposition, it wasn't just breaking with its past policy of ignoring political dynamics in countries it invests in. Beijing is now taking on a role New Delhi should have been in a better position to play, and by refusing to play it Delhi is being shown up as unfeeling, partisan or, worse, ineffec-

GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO



tive in the bargain.

The third issue is that the Modi government's decision to use hard power tactics in the neighbourhood has had a boomerang effect. Theoretically, given its central location in South Asia and being the largest geographically and economically, India should be expected to hold greater sway over each of its neighbours. However, the "surgical strikes" on Pakistan of 2016 have been followed by a greater number of ceasefire violations and cross-border infiltration on the Line of Control. The 2015 Nepal blockade and a subsequent cut in Indian aid channelled through the government did not force the Nepali government to amend its constitution as intended, and the subsequent merger of Mr. Oli's Communist Party of Nepal (UML) with Prachanda's CPN(Maoist) is seen as a reversal of India's influence there.

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last week about immigration has drawn ire there, with Bangladesh's Home Minister Asaduzzaman Khan describing the remarks as untrue, unfounded and not helpful.

While many of these factors are hard to reverse, the fundamental facts of geography and shared cultures in South Asia are also undeniable, and India must focus its efforts to return to a more comfortable peace, and to "Making the Neighbourhood First Again".

Time for reversal

To begin with, despite conventional wisdom on the benefits of hard power and realpolitik, India's most potent tool is its soft power. Its successes in Bhutan and Afghanistan, for example, have much more to do with its development assistance than its defence assistance. It's heartening, therefore, that after sharp drops in 2016 (of 36%) and 2017 (of 19%) year on year, the budget allocations for South Asia have seen an increase (of 6%) in 2018. After the Doklam crisis was defused in 2017, India also moved swiftly to resolve differences with Bhutan on hydropower pricing, and this February it announced a tariff hike for energy from Bhutan's Chhukha project, the first in several years.

Next, instead of opposing every project by China in the region, the government must attempt a three-pronged approach. First, where possible, India should collaborate with China in the manner it has over the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar (BCIM) Economic corridor. Second, when it feels a project is a threat to its interests, India should make a counter-offer to the project, if necessary in collaboration with its Quadrilateral partn-

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This will all only be possible if India and China reset bilateral ties, which have seen a marked slide over the past few years. It is noteworthy that the government appears to have started this process with Foreign Secretary Vijay Gokhale's recent visit to Beijing.

Learning from ASEAN

It will also be impossible to renew the compact with the neighbours without reviving the SAARC process. In their book *The ASEAN Miracle*, Kishore Mahbubani and Jeffery Sng describe in detail the need for SAARC to learn from the success of ASEAN. Mr. Mahbubani suggests that leaders of SAARC countries meet more often informally, that they interfere less in the internal workings of each other's governments, and that there be more interaction at every level of government. They also say that just as Indonesia, the biggest economy in the ASEAN, allowed smaller countries such as Singapore to take the lead, India too must take a back seat in decision-making, enabling others to build a more harmonious SAARC process.

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THE HINDU
INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

7th March, 2018

4 Make the neighbourhood first again

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SURANJAN DAS

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SAARC COUNTRIES

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IMPORTANT QUESTION

ESSAY/ MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

The need of the hour for India is to reinvigorate the "Neighbourhood First Policy". Critically examine.

NEIGHBOURHOOD FIRST POLICY IS ON DOWNWARD SPIRAL

1

MALDIVES



- President Yameen Abdul Gayoom gone out of his way to challenge the Modi Govt. against the wishes of India.
- He resorted to crack down on Opposition.
- In fact, he sent invitation to China.
- To isolate Pakistan at SAARC, Maldives broke with New Delhi's effort.

A map showing Sri Lanka and the Maldives. Sri Lanka is a large island in the upper right, labeled 'SRI LANKA'. The Maldives is a chain of smaller islands to the southwest, with a red line pointing to one of them. A large red and yellow box contains the text 'Makunudhoo Island' and 'MALDIVES'. The background is blue with a repeating 'Learning Space' logo.

SRI
LANKA

Makunudhoo Island
MALDIVES

NEIGHBOURHOOD FIRST POLICY IS ON DOWNWARD SPIRAL

2

NEPAL



- K. P. Sharma Oli Govt. first choice is not certainly India.
- Kathmandu invited Pakistani Prime Minister this week.



K. P. Sharma Oli

NEIGHBOURHOOD FIRST POLICY IS ON DOWNWARD SPIRAL

3 PAKISTAN



- Cross-border firing incidents continuing unabated.
- Whatever the party in power in Pakistan, India is not able to push for official dialogue.
- Military is on the ascendant once again.

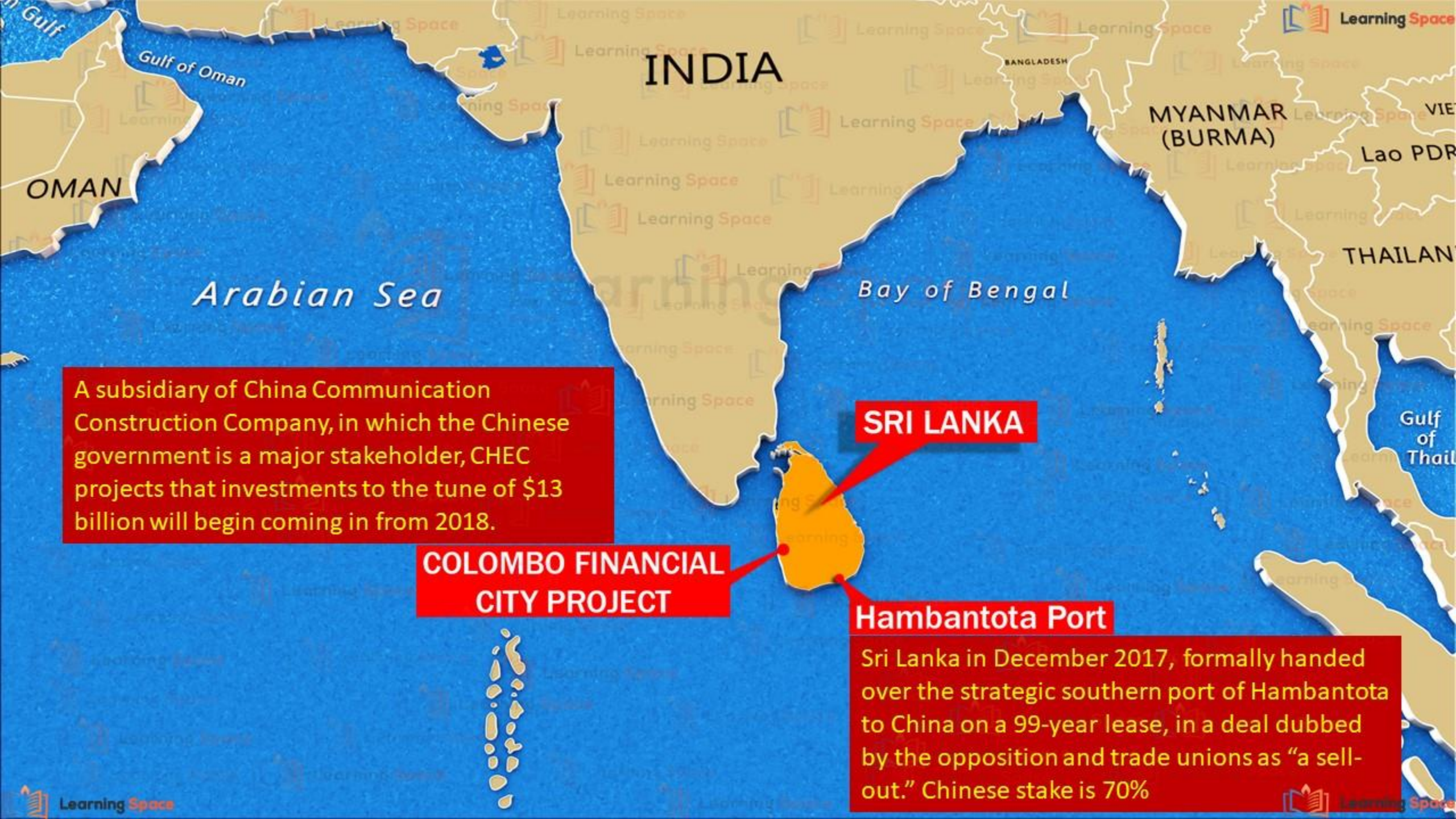
NEIGHBOURHOOD FIRST POLICY IS ON DOWNWARD SPIRAL

4 SRI LANKA



- Recent local election results have gone the way of Mahinda Rajapaksa backed party.
- It gave signals of his future re-election and he is known for his pro-China stance.

In Afghanistan, Bhutan and Bangladesh, elections this year could pose challenges for India.



INDIA

OMAN

Arabian Sea

Bay of Bengal

MYANMAR
(BURMA)

Lao PDR

THAILAND

Gulf of
Thailand

A subsidiary of China Communication Construction Company, in which the Chinese government is a major stakeholder, CHEC projects that investments to the tune of \$13 billion will begin coming in from 2018.

SRI LANKA

COLOMBO FINANCIAL
CITY PROJECT

Hambantota Port

Sri Lanka in December 2017, formally handed over the strategic southern port of Hambantota to China on a 99-year lease, in a deal dubbed by the opposition and trade unions as "a sell-out." Chinese stake is 70%



CHINA'S UNPRECEDENTED FORAYS

1 China opened up alternative trade and connective options to Nepal after 2015 India-Nepal border blockade and they include highways, cross-border railway lines to the development of dry ports.

2 In Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Maldives and Pakistan, China holds strategic real estate and they can be fortified militarily in the future.

3 China's growing presence in infrastructure and connectivity projects is another aspect.

4 China stepped in to negotiate a Rohingya refugee return agreement between Myanmar and Bangladesh.

5 It is conducting meetings of Afghanistan and Pakistan's foreign ministers to help calm the tensions.

6 It offered to mediate between Maldivian Govt. and the Opposition.

China broke with its past policy of ignoring political dynamics in countries it invests in.



WHAT WENT WRONG IN RECENT TIMES?

- 1** The surgical strikes on Pakistan in 2016 have been followed by a greater number of ceasefire violations and cross-border infiltrations on the LoC.
- 2** Subsequent to the Nepal blockade, the Govt. of Nepal did not amend the Constitution as intended by India.
- 3** Subsequent merger of CPN (UML) and CPN (Maoist) is seen as a reversal of India's influence.
- 4** The abrupt cancellation of Indian Prime Minister's visit to Male in 2015 did not yield the required changes in the Govt's treatment of the Opposition in Maldives.
- 5** Now Maldives cancelled its participation in the Indian Navy's "MILAN" exercises.

India must focus its efforts to return to a more comfortable peace and to "Making the Neighbourhood First Again".

SOFT POWER

The use of a country's cultural and economic influence to persuade other countries to do something, rather than the use of military power



HARD POWER

The use of a country's military power to persuade other countries to do something, rather than the use of cultural or economic influence



INDIA'S MOST POTENTIAL TOOL IS SOFT POWER



- 1** After the Doklam crisis, India moved swiftly to resolve differences with Bhutan on hydro-power pricing.
- 2** Last month, it announced a tariff hike for energy from Bhutan's Chhukha project and this is the first in several years.

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE?

Instead of opposing every project by China in the region, the Govt. should attempt a three-pronged approach.

- 1) Wherever possible India should collaborate with China in the manner it has done over the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar (BCIM) Economic Corridor.
- 2) Whenever it feels a project is a threat to its interests, it should make a counter-offer to the project, if necessary in collaboration with Quad.
- 3) India should coexist with projects that do not necessitate intervention, while formulating a set of South Asian principles for sustainable development assistance that can be used across the region.

This is possible, if India and China reset bilateral ties, which have seen a marked slide over the past few years.

ASEAN EXPERIENCE CAN BE AN EXAMPLE



- 1** There is a need for SAARC to learn from the success of ASEAN.
- 2** ASEAN leaders in spite of contradictions, allowed the cementing of the bonds in due course of time.
- 3** Indonesia is the biggest economy in the ASEAN, but allowed the smaller countries such as Singapore to take the lead.
- 4** India must take a back seat in decision-making, enabling others to build a more harmonious SAARC process.



सत्यमेव जयते

The Indian Govt's challenge is to steer India towards a course, where it is both feared and loved in appropriate measure and away from a situation in which it is neither feared nor loved.

WE EXPRESS OUR SINCERE THANKS FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

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